

Model of Group Socialization – Levine, Moreland, and Ryan (1998).

Discussion of the stages of socialization which is relevant to ethical issues faced by CSE professionals in modern technology organizations

Model of group socialization and ethical challenges for CSE professionals in different stages

The Model of Group Socialization describes how individuals and groups influence each other over time through changing levels of commitment. Membership in a group is not static; rather, it progresses through a series of stages, each with distinct expectations, evaluations, and ethical challenges. For CSE professionals, this model is particularly relevant because ethical decision-making in computing is affected by organizational culture, power relations, and professional norms, not just technical expertise.

1. Investigation Stage (Prospective Member): In the investigation stage, individuals evaluate whether to join a group, and the group evaluates whether the individual is a good fit. Technology companies often emphasize innovation, impact, and career growth, while ethical risks may be hidden or minimized. Prospective engineers may ignore ethical concerns due to economic pressure or fear of unemployment.

Example: A CSE graduate applies to a social media company that collects large volumes of user data.

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Although the applicant is aware of past privacy controversies, they rationalize that “every company does this” and proceed with the job application. *Ethical issue:* Lack of informed consent and ethical transparency during recruitment.

2. Entry and Socialization Stage (New Member): During socialization, new members learn group norms, technical practices, and informal rules. Commitment increases as acceptance by the group becomes important. Unethical practices can become normalized through training and peer behavior. New engineers are vulnerable to conformity pressure and may suppress ethical doubts.

Example: A newly hired software engineer is trained to optimize engagement by using dark patterns that encourage addictive user behavior. Senior engineers describe this as “just good user experience (UX).” *Ethical issue:* Manipulation of users and erosion of informed user choice.

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3. Acceptance and Maintenance Stage (Full Member): At this stage, the individual becomes a full member, actively contributing to the group's goals. Commitment is typically at its highest. Full members often gain authority but also share responsibility for harmful outcomes. Ethical blindness may occur when success is measured purely by performance metrics.

Example: A senior developer works on an AI-based hiring system. Even after discovering biased outcomes against certain social groups, the engineer continues deployment due to deadlines and business pressure. *Ethical issue:* Algorithmic bias and failure to protect social justice due to organizational priorities.

4. Divergence Stage (Marginal Member): Divergence occurs when the evaluations of the individual and the group no longer align, causing commitment to decline. Ethical conflicts become visible when engineers question organizational decisions. Individuals may face isolation or subtle punishment for raising concerns.

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Example: An engineer raises concerns about facial recognition software being sold to law enforcement. Management dismisses the concern as “not our responsibility.” *Ethical issue:* Conflict between professional ethics and corporate interests.

5. Resocialization Stage (Marginal Member): In resocialization, the group attempts to restore commitment, or the individual tries to adapt again to group norms. Organizations may attempt to silence ethical criticism through reassignment or persuasion. Engineers may experience moral stress when pressured to compromise values. *Example:* The engineer is reassigned to a different team and encouraged to “focus on technical excellence, not politics.” *Ethical Issues:* suppression of ethical dissent and avoidance of accountability.

6. *Exit Stage (Ex-Member):* If resocialization fails, the individual exits the group, either voluntarily or involuntarily. Exit may be the only ethical option when harm continues. Leaving can involve professional risk and loss of influence.

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Example A developer resigns from a company producing spyware after internal objections fail. *Ethical issue*: Balancing personal integrity against career stability.

7. Remembrance Stage (Ex-Member): In the remembrance stage, former members reinterpret their experiences and maintain or sever ties with the group. Reflection may lead to whistleblowing, advocacy, or ethical reform. Former employees can influence public debate on technology ethics. *Example*: A former employee publishes research exposing unethical data practices and advocates for stronger AI regulation. *Ethical issue*: Social responsibility beyond organizational loyalty.

Ethical competence therefore requires not only technical skill but also Ethical awareness, Critical thinking, Moral courage.

Understanding Cyberbullying

1. **Definitional Issues in Cyberbullying:** Cyberbullying is an intentional, aggressive behavior carried out via electronic means, repeatedly and over time, against a victim who cannot easily defend themselves. This definition is derived from traditional bullying research but presents unique difficulties when applied to online contexts. Two major definitional challenges are emphasized:

Repetition: In cyberbullying, a single act (such as uploading a photo) can be repeatedly experienced by the victim if it is shared by others. This complicates the question of whether repetition must be performed by the original perpetrator.

Power imbalance: Traditional power indicators such as physical strength are less relevant online. Instead, power may arise from anonymity, technical expertise, or the difficulty of removing harmful online content.

Understanding Cyberbullying

2. Types and Forms of Cyberbullying: The article emphasizes that cyberbullying is not a single behavior, but occurs in diverse forms. Cyberbullying can be categorized by:

Medium: text messages, emails, instant messaging, websites, social networking sites, online games.

Type of action: threats, harassment, spreading rumors, exclusion, impersonation, posting humiliating images or videos.

Technological developments continually generate new forms of cyberbullying, making the phenomenon dynamic and difficult to fully capture with fixed categories.

Understanding Cyberbullying

3. Age and Gender Patterns: Cyberbullying peaks during early to mid-adolescence, especially around ages 13–15. Involvement tends to decline after adolescence, though it does not disappear entirely. Some studies find higher involvement among boys, others find no difference, and some report higher involvement among girls, particularly in relational or indirect forms of cyberbullying. Gender differences are influenced by methodology, definitions, and changing communication practices.

4. Relationship with Traditional Bullying: There is strong overlap between traditional bullying and cyberbullying. Individuals involved in face-to-face bullying are often also involved in cyberbullying. Cyberbullying incidents frequently originate from offline conflicts and then continue online, or vice versa. This suggests that cyberbullying should not be seen as entirely separate, but rather as part of a broader pattern of aggressive peer interactions.

Understanding Cyberbullying

5. Differences Between Cyberbullying and Traditional Bullying:

- Cyberbullying can be anonymous
- The perpetrator often does not see the victim's immediate reaction
- The audience can be very large, increasing embarrassment and distress
- There is no clear safe space, as cyberbullying can occur at any time and place
- Bystander (eyewitiness) roles are more complex than in traditional bullying

These features can intensify the experience for victims and complicate responses by adults and institutions.

Understanding Cyberbullying

6. Impact on Victims: A wide range of negative emotional effects, including: Anger, Fear, Stress, Loneliness, Embarrassment, Depression and so on may occur. While some victims report being “not bothered,” many experience long-lasting emotional consequences, especially when cyberbullying is persistent, anonymous, or widely shared. Cyberbullying and traditional bullying have broadly similar negative impacts, though specific features of cyberbullying may increase harm in certain circumstances.